PROactive PRONUNCIATION

Phrasing Practice

Punctuation marks are always pausing or phrasing breaks. When you see conjunctions (e.g., and/but/or) and prepositions (e.g., in/on/about), those are great spots to pause as well. Read the words aloud. Take a pause or easy breath between each "thought group."

Below is an excerpt of Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr.'s "I Have A Dream" speech. This passage purposefully has no punctuation marks. Read it out loud and practice placing your pauses to separate the thought groups in the passage.

"And so even though we face the difficulties of today and tomorrow I still have a dream it is a dream deeply rooted in the American dream I have a dream that one day this nation will rise up and live out the true meaning of its creed we hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created equal I have a dream that one day on the red hills of Georgia the sons of former slaves and the sons of former slave owners will be able to sit down together at the table of brotherhood I have a dream that one day even the state of Mississippi a state sweltering with the heat of injustice sweltering with the heat of oppression will be transformed into an oasis of freedom and justice I have a dream that my four little children will one day live in a nation where they will not be judged by the color of their skin but by the content of their character I have a dream today"